Han ethnic group, the Qing added significant territories of Inner Asia, [1] including Manchuria (currently China's north-eastern provinces of Liaoning, Jilin and Heilongjiang), Mongolia (both the current province of Inner Mongolia and the now independent Mongolian People's Republic), the Tarim Basin and the oasis towns on its periphery (the province of Xinjiang established in 1884), and the vast Tibetan plateau, now constituted by the provinces of Ningxia and Qinghai and the autonomous region of Tibet.

The Manchus administered these territories as separate categories, the Han heartland being described as the 'inner domains', while the non-Han areas were known as the 'outer domains'. The outer domains were under a special agency called the Lifanyuan, which supervised the empire's ritual and administrative relations with the non-Han entities.

The Qing empire was one of the most prosperous in Chinese history. Agricultural production increased significantly, both on account of the introduction of new crops from the New World, such as groundnut, maize and potato; and expansion of acreage under agriculture with the colonization of newly conquered lands and their settlement by Han migrant populations. Such migration was encouraged by the Qing rulers in areas such as Mongolia and Xinjiang. Manchuria, the homeland of the Manchu rulers, was supposed to be out of bounds, but over time Han settlers occupied much of the north-eastern parts of the empire too. The growing prosperity was reflected in the population expanding from 150 million at the time the Qing empire was established in the seventeenth century to 450 million when the empire came to an end in the early part of the twentieth century.

The demographic profile of China underwent a significant change. The already densely populated areas of the heartland, the Yangzi and Huang He river valleys and the eastern coastal plains became even more congested, leading to Han settlements spreading into the more sparsely populated non-Han parts of the Qing empire. When nationalism appeared as a potent force during the declining years of the Qing dynasty, the dynasty encompassed territories which were originally not part of the Chinese heartland but had